# A Word is Worth A Thousand Words: Biased Beliefs about Political Language Use*

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**Abstract**

In a time when politics seem to be polarized as ever, it isn't surprising that language use may be polarized too. If people define words in different ways, then using those words to describe their political positions can result in being perceived as more (less) extreme than they actually are. I conducted a survey with 782 MTurk workers in the U.S., eliciting their definition of the term "Democratic Socialism". This included asking them to predict how others would define the word, as well as a treatment group that received financial incentives based on predictive accuracy. I find that there is a large discrepancy between those on the Left and Right when defining the word. Financial incentives increase predictive accuracy more for those on the Right more than those on the Left or Moderates. More importantly, people from both groups made errors when predicting how others would define the word, but the nature of these errors was asymmetric across parties. In particular, those on the Right tended to make similar predictions for others on the Left versus Right, whereas those on the Left believed others on the Left were more likely to agree with them. False Consensus Effect was approximately 3 times more prevalent than Pluralistic Ignorance, especially amongst others who shared your political views.

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# 1 Introduction and Background

> "*For Republicans, both then and now, socialism is something much scarier. We're talking about two very, very different things but oftentimes using the same term.*"
> -Sheri Berman, Author of *The Primacy of Politics*.

People often engage in political discussions with others – sometimes with those across the aisle – and things often end in heated disagreements. While many of these might be genuine disagreements in values and policy opinions, others might simply be miscommunication due to varying "personal definitions" of certain buzzwords.

For instance, suppose someone on the left and right both want an economy that has free markets, with some level of public goods and redistribution. This is precisely what the USA (and most countries around the world) currently are, with varying levels of public good provisions and tax rates. Suppose someone on the left, let's call him Ben, wants this exact system – but to add a couple of public goods (healthcare, free college) – and in their mind this new state with those added public goods is called "Democratic Socialism". Further, suppose Ben defines capitalism as a system where government provides no public goods, leaving people with an inequality of opportunity.

On the other hand, suppose someone on the right, let's call her Amy, wants this exact system as well, perhaps with a slightly lower tax rate. However, they define this as "capitalist". Further, suppose Amy defines "Socialist" (Democratic or otherwise) in a way that bans free markets, and involves central allocation of goods. To Amy, someone claiming that they want Democratic Socialism is akin to saying that they want to outlaw entrepreneurship and private ownership of businesses.

Suppose that Ben and Amy find themselves in a "comment war" (or a rare, civilized discussion) on twitter. These two people have a very similar position on what an ideal economic system should look like, differing only on a precise tax rate. Yet, if Ben confidently uses the term Democratic Socialist to describe his views and argues in favor of socialism, and Amy confidently uses the word capitalism to describe her ideal view, then each will think that the discrepancy between their perceived worldviews is very large. They will talk past each other, with Ben stating why equality is important and Amy stating why markets are

important. They both may leave the discussion even more entrenched in their own views, but also, importantly, with a biased perception of the ideal policy goals of people on the other side of the aisle.

While there are genuine differences in policy goals between Amy and Ben, a part of the perceived discrepancy is based on how they each define a certain word, and in no case does either person realize what the other person's definition of the word is. They each might believe that the way they personally define the word is the objectively correct "dictionary" definition of the word, and therefore others define the word the same way. This is called the **False Consensus Effect**. If they believe everyone defines the word the way they do, they may infer wildly incorrect things about others' policy views. This may even lead them to vote for the wrong politician (one further in ideology from them than the alternative).

On the other hand, they may think that those on the other side of the aisle systematically define buzz words differently; this is called **Pluralistic Ignorance**. This may make their inferences on others' policy positions either more biased or less biased, depending on the way in which they believe the word definitions vary (Bohren and Hauser, 2019). This notion of viewing in- and out- groups differently from each other is an interdisciplinary result from multiple fields that study political polarization (Finkel et al., 2020).

In this paper, I will elicit participants' definitions of potentially ambiguous political terms, and will then ask participants to predict how they believe others would define the word. Note that recent work has shown that un-incentivized surveys often result in untruthful answers, sometimes taking the form of "Partisan Cheerleading" (Gerber and Huber, 2010; Peterson and Iyengar, 2021). However, this has recently also come into question when McGrath et al. (2017) found that the effect disappears when removing certain jurisdictions from an otherwise large dataset. In order to contribute to the this literature as well as be sure that results from these types of surveys aren't mostly untruthful responses, I will provide a financial incentive for accuracy to half of the participants at random.

Recent studies that have discovered the existence of biased beliefs have subsequently experimented with "de-biasing" participants to see if it leads to behavior change (Bursztyn et al., 2020). Similarly, results from this survey which will provide me with an estimate of the percentage of those on the Left and Right who agree with certain statements can then

be used to "de-bias" people (if such a bias exists). An experiment that de-biases their beliefs on how certain words are defined by people across the aisle can then be used to measure any difference in interpretation of News Headlines as in Thaler (2020), for example.

# 2 Research Questions

In this paper, I will address the following questions:

1. To what extent do people on the Left vs Right define Democratic Socialism differently?
2. Do individuals hold biased beliefs about how others define Democratic Socialism?
3. Can financial incentives improve predictive accuracy?
4. To what extent are *False Consensus Effect* and *Pluralistic Ignorance* prevalent in this context, and do these vary for predictions about in- versus out- group members?

# 3 Theoretical Framework

Here, I will briefly show how defining a word differently than someone else may lead to sub-optimal voting.

## 3.1 Set Up

- **Party**: $\pi \in \{D, R\}$
- **Definition**: $\delta \in \{1, 2\}$
- **Word Use**: $\omega \in \{-1, 1\}$

Suppose $I$ is the incumbent candidate, and $p$ is the policy position (such as the tax rate) that a candidate can choose. Suppose voter $j$'s utility is given by

$$u_j(p) = -|p - p_j|$$

implying that their ideal position is to vote for a candidate who supports policy position $p = p_j$.

Their beliefs about the policy position of a candidate is $\mu_j(p|\pi, \omega)$ implying that they are voting based on the politician's party and the words the politician uses to describe their positions. Suppose voter $j$'s definition of the word is $\delta_j = 1$, and let a new politician's definition be given by $\delta_{-j}$.

Let's define

$$\mu_j(p|\pi, \omega = 1, \delta_{-j} = 1) = p_1$$

and

$$\mu_j(p|\pi, \omega = 1, \delta_{-j} = 2) = p_2$$

and $p_I$ is the policy position of the incumbent.

Then, if

$$u(p_2) > u(p_I) > u(p_1)$$

then the voter would mistakenly vote for the incumbent instead of the new candidate if they believed the definition was $\delta_{-j} = 1$ when the politician believes $\delta_{-j} = 2$. Vice versa, they would mistakenly vote for the new candidate instead of the incumbent if they believed the definition was $\delta = 2$ when the politician believes $\delta = 1$.

In this context, *False Consensus Effect* is when individual $i$ believes $\delta_{-j} = \delta_j$ is more likely to be true than it actually is. What this thought experiment shows is that a rational voter who makes decisions based on signals (word usage) from politicians may mistakenly vote for for someone ideologically further than a feasible alternative if they misinterpret the signal by using a different definition of the word than the politician is using. This is consequential as it highlights an inefficiency in the democratic process because of biased beliefs on word definitions.

# 4 Survey and Experimental Design

One primary purpose of the survey is to understand whether people hold biased beliefs about word usages, and whether these are asymmetric across the aisle. In order to oper-

ationalize this, I will pick a single true-false question as my main variable of interest as opposed to open-ended definitions that become difficult to interpret. Even though there are many possible ways in which one could define "Democratic Socialism", one crucial aspect of that definition is whether or not businesses are state-owned, and whether individuals are allowed to start their own businesses. This is a crucial aspect of the overall definition, and it would be good to know if there are substantial disagreements about it. So, I ask the following **True or False** question:

> **In a Democratic Socialist country, there can only brand brand of pizza (by definition).**

I also collect demographic questions: age, gender, income, race, and education, in addition to asking them to choose whether they consider themselves politically Left, Moderate, or Right.

I then ask them to predict what fraction of those on the Left, Moderate, and Right respectively they think would answer "True" to the "One Brand of Pizza" question they were just asked.

While I also collect similar results for other questions involving the definitions of "racist" and "feminist", I only analyze the results for the Democratic Socialism question in this paper.

The second goal of the design is to test whether financial incentives improve accuracy of predictions (or change responses in any way, such as mitigating instances of partisan cheerleading). In this context, one instantiation of partisan cheerleading might be giving knowingly inaccurate answers painting the opposition as having more extreme definitions of words than they really believe. Incentivizing accuracy of their predictions might mitigate this.

So, the control group was paid 50 cents for a 10-minute survey and asked to make predictions, whereas the treatment group was additionally told that **the top 5% of respondents** (measured by average prediction accuracy) in the treatment group **would receive a $10 bonus** each. This amounts to an expected value of $\$10 \times 0.05 = \$0.50$. In effect, this doubles their compensation for the survey. The full survey is available in the Appendix below.

# 5 Data

Participants in this study were MTurk workers who filled out the survey on Qualtrics (consent form is in the Appendix just before the survey) between August 25th and August 29th, 2021. Participants were restricted to residents living within the United States between the ages of 18 and 65, and were stratified by age and political views in order to be more representative of the U.S. voting population, as opposed to that of a randomly selected set of MTurk workers.

In particular, I selected an approximately equal number of participants who self-identified as being politically "Left" and politically "Right", as well as an approximately equal number of participants in each of the following age ranges: 18-25, 25-30, 30-35, 35-45, 45-55, 55+. The total sample size was 782 participants, of which 389 were Control and 393 were Treatment.

Table 1: Balance Table (Original Data)

| | Control | | | Treatment | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Variable | n | mean | sd | n | mean | sd | Diff |
| Male | 383 | 0.44 | 0.50 | 387 | 0.47 | 0.50 | 0.032 |
| Over 37 (Age) | 389 | 0.48 | 0.50 | 393 | 0.49 | 0.50 | 0.005 |
| Left | 389 | 0.35 | 0.48 | 393 | 0.34 | 0.47 | -0.011 |
| Right | 389 | 0.34 | 0.48 | 393 | 0.37 | 0.48 | 0.030 |
| Moderate | 389 | 0.31 | 0.46 | 393 | 0.29 | 0.45 | -0.018 |
| Black | 355 | 0.14 | 0.35 | 362 | 0.12 | 0.32 | -0.022 |
| Graduate Degree | 389 | 0.26 | 0.44 | 393 | 0.22 | 0.42 | -0.041 |
| Over $60k Income | 383 | 0.38 | 0.49 | 384 | 0.38 | 0.49 | -0.004 |
| Passed Attention | 389 | 0.93 | 0.26 | 393 | 0.95 | 0.21 | 0.029* |

*Note*: All variables here are binary, so the mean represents the percentage. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Table 1 is a balance table with variables, showing both that there is no significant difference between the treatment and control groups, as well as the balance between political ideology. Note that all variables on this table are binary, though some variables originally had more than two categories that were collapsed into two groups here.

Note that 93% passed the attention question in the control group, whereas 95% passed the attention question in the treatment group, and this difference was statistically significant at the $\alpha = 0.10$ level. This is reasonable, since the treatment group is more likely to pay

closer attention given the added financial incentive for accuracy. Since responses from those who failed the attention question are not reliable, I dropped those observations, leaving me with a final sample size of 735 (360 Control, 375 Treatment).

One caveat here is that dropping these observations might inherently make the treatment and control groups different from each other since the type of person who would pass the attention question only when incentivized is present in the treatment group but not in the (new) control group. While we can't rule this out, a new balance test in Table 2 shows that all of the demographic variables for which I have data are still balanced across treatment and control, which gives us some confidence that ceteris paribus between treatment and control still holds.

Table 2: Balance Table (After Dropping for Attention)

| | Control | | | Treatment | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Variable | n | mean | sd | n | mean | sd | Diff |
| Male | 354 | 0.44 | 0.50 | 369 | 0.47 | 0.50 | 0.034 |
| Over 37 (Age) | 360 | 0.50 | 0.50 | 375 | 0.50 | 0.50 | -0.001 |
| Left | 360 | 0.37 | 0.48 | 375 | 0.34 | 0.47 | -0.031 |
| Right | 360 | 0.33 | 0.47 | 375 | 0.38 | 0.49 | 0.048 |
| Moderate | 360 | 0.30 | 0.46 | 375 | 0.28 | 0.45 | -0.017 |
| Black | 327 | 0.14 | 0.35 | 344 | 0.11 | 0.31 | -0.027 |
| Graduate Degree | 360 | 0.26 | 0.44 | 375 | 0.22 | 0.42 | -0.043 |
| Over $60k Income | 355 | 0.39 | 0.49 | 368 | 0.38 | 0.49 | -0.008 |

*Note*: All variables here are binary, so the mean represents the percentage. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

# 6 Results and Discussion

In this section, I will primarily discuss the results surrounding the first main question in the survey: "True or False: **In a Democratic Socialist country, there can only be one brand of pizza (by definition)**." Table 3 shows the proportion of the self-identified Left, Moderate, and Right respectively who said "True" to the question.

We see here that those on the Right are more than twice as likely as those on the Left to say true to this question, and moderates are in between. These differences are statistically

| | % Who said True | Sample Size (N) |
|---|---|---|
| Left | **19.8%** | 258 |
| Moderate | **36.9%** | 214 |
| Right | **47.9%** | 263 |

Table 3: Proportion who said "True" to the Pizza question by ideology

significant (pairwise) from each other at the $\alpha = 0.01$ level.

Then comes the question of how participants of each ideology predicted the proportion that would respond "True" from each ideology. This is shown in Table 5, where row shows the predictor and columns are the group whose values are being predicted.

Predictor (rows):

| | Left | Mod | Right |
|---|---|---|---|
| Left | 28.7% | 35.5% | 49.0% |
| Moderate | 40.4% | 45.2% | 49.3% |
| Right | 40.1% | 43.7% | 51.9% |

Table 4: Predictions about “Pizza" question. The rows represent the group predicting, and the column refers to who they are predicting about.

Within each ideology, we can see that participants on average predict that the Left is least likely to say true and the Right is most likely, a relationship that was true in my sample. However, this table masks large variances in prediction, and so I will instead focus on the "*absolute value* of the difference between one's prediction and the true result" as the outcome of interest when it comes to measuring prediction accuracy.

With that definition of prediction error, Table 5 shows the prediction error when predicting for those on the Left, Right, and Moderates. The omitted group in the regression here is the Moderates:

Here we can see that there is no significant difference in prediction accuracy when it comes to predicting for the left. Those on the Right are modestly less likely to make prediction errors about moderates than moderates themselves (this effect is around 0.16 Standard Deviations, given the 2.35 point error difference and that the standard deviation here is 15.1 points).

Those on the left are significantly more likely than moderates to make a prediction error however, when predicting for those on the right (0.26 SD effect). A separate regression (not listed here) would also show that the difference between the left and right in predicting for the right is also statistically significant (p=0.035), with the left having a larger prediction

| | Error (Left) | Error (Moderates) | Error (Right) |
|---|---|---|---|
| Right | -0.581 | -2.350* | 1.228 |
| | (1.882) | (1.392) | (1.498) |
| Left | -2.699 | -1.208 | 4.246*** |
| | (1.891) | (1.398) | (1.505) |
| Constant | 29.03*** | 24.61*** | 22.83*** |
| | (1.398) | (1.033) | (1.113) |
| Observations | 735 | 735 | 735 |
| R-squared | 0.003 | 0.004 | 0.012 |

Standard errors in parentheses
*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Table 5: Prediction Errors (output) by Ideology (moderates are the omitted group)

error (0.18 SD).

Next, I look at how the financial incentive may have impacted the prediction error for each type of ideology. Table 6 uses the same error as before as the outcome variable, but now includes a treatment indicator as well as interaction terms for treatment with "left" and "right" ideologies to see how the treatment effect varies across groups:

Here, we can see that there is no significant treatment effect for predictions for either the Left or Moderates, and for predictions about the Right, the moderates in the treatment group (first row) actually had a higher (significant at $\alpha = 0.10$) prediction error than the control group moderates. The control group of the left (2nd row) made significantly higher errors than any other group (significant at $\alpha = 0.01$). Those on the right had a significant (at $\alpha = 0.10$) treatment effect relative to moderates. This implies that financial incentives improve accuracy more for those on the right than for moderates, when predicting for those on the right.

Overall, there doesn't appear to be much of a difference in prediction errors when participants are incentivized.

| | Error (Left) | Error (Moderates) | Error (Right) |
|---|---|---|---|
| Treat | 1.699 | 3.280 | 3.764* |
| | (2.799) | (2.067) | (2.225) |
| Left | -2.462 | 0.776 | 6.096*** |
| | (2.656) | (1.962) | (2.111) |
| Left × Treat | -0.460 | -4.014 | -3.733 |
| | (3.787) | (2.796) | (3.009) |
| Right | -0.773 | -0.382 | 3.758* |
| | (2.716) | (2.005) | (2.158) |
| Right × Treat | 0.203 | -3.911 | -4.989* |
| | (3.776) | (2.788) | (3.001) |
| Constant | 28.19*** | 22.99*** | 20.97*** |
| | (1.970) | (1.455) | (1.566) |
| Observations | 735 | 735 | 735 |
| R-squared | 0.005 | 0.008 | 0.016 |

Standard errors in parentheses
*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Table 6: Treatment Effect of Prediction Errors (output) by Ideology (moderates omitted)

## 6.1 In-Group versus Out-Group Predictions

Next, I analyze participants' predictions about the fraction of other people that agree with them. I separate this by "in-group" and "out-group" beliefs by looking at the Left's prediction about others on the Left (in-group) as opposed to their predictions about those on the Right (out-group), and vice-versa for those on the Right. For this analysis, I am only looking at the subset of participants who identified as Left or Right (thereby not including moderates), which leaves me with a sample size of 521.

I constructed two variables, *Ingroup-Agree* and *Outgroup-Agree* as follows:

- For those on the Left (Right) who answered "True", the variable *Ingroup-Agree* is their prediction for the percentage on the Left (Right) who answered True.
- For those on the Left (Right) who answered "False", the variable *Ingroup-Agree* is their

prediction for the percentage on the Left (Right) who answered False.

- For those on the Left (Right) who answered "True", the variable *Outgroup-Agree* is their prediction for the percentage on the Right (Left) who answered True.
- For those on the Left (Right) who answered "False", the variable *Outgroup-Agree* is their prediction for the percentage on the Right (Left) who answered False.

Table 7 shows the predictions for the percentage who would agree with them, as well as whether there is a difference between one's ingroup and outgroup predictions:

| | In-Group % Agree | Out-Group % Agree | P-Value |
|---|---|---|---|
| Left (N=258) | **74.3%** | **51.9%** | 0.000*** |
| Right (N=263) | **61.1%** | **61.2%** | 0.964 |

Table 7: Predictions for the % who agree with one's answer to the Pizza question

This shows that while those on the Right, on average, predict that a similar proportion of people on the Left and Right will agree with their definition, the Left believes that those with similar beliefs are substantially more likely to agree with their definition than those across the political aisle. This is consistent with the asymmetry found in Grossmann and Hopkins (2015), where those on the Right are more likely to be ideologically driven. The parallel here is that those on the right are more likely to view a word as being defined similarly by those on the left versus the right, thereby viewing their differences as ideological rather than rooted in defining a word differently.

## 6.2 False Consensus Effect and Pluralistic Ignorance

While the analysis above is useful for understanding whether people's beliefs about "consensus" (agreeing with them) is different for in- versus out-of-group members, this doesn't tell us anything about whether there is a particular bias. If their predictions are in fact accurate, the consensus couldn't be considered a "false" consensus.

So, in order to analyze whether there is a *False Consensus Effect* present, I compare their predictions about the percentage who agree with them with the *actual percentage* who agree with them. In particular, I define the variable False Consensus Effect (FCE) as:

- For those who answered "True", the FCE is the predicted percentage who said True minus the actual percentage who said True.
- For those who answered "False", the FCE is the predicted percentage who said False minus the actual percentage who said False.

Thus, the FCE variable is positive when one predicted a higher percentage of people agreed with their answer than actually did. A negative FCE variable implies that in fact more people agreed with their answer than predicted. A negative FCE therefore conceptually implies **Pluralistic Ignorance**.

Finally, in order to not make sure that results are not being driven by intensity of a few people having a high magnitude of FCE, I define two binary variables as follows:

- **FCE_10**: 1 if one's FCE value is greater than 10, 0 otherwise.
- **PI_10**: 1 if one's FCE value is below $-10$, 0 otherwise.

Additionally, I calculate these variables separately for Ingroup versus Outgroup predictions to see if people hold these biases differently for in versus out group members. As a robustness check, I also a created a version of these variables where the cutoff to be classified as FCE or PI is at 5 rather than 10 percentage points, and the results were qualitatively similar. Same was the case when I used the continuous measure of FCE rather than the binary version. Table 8 shows the proportion of participants with False Consensus Effect for In versus Out group:

| | In-Group FCE_10 | Out-Group FCE_10 | P-Value |
|---|---|---|---|
| Left (N=258) | **57.4%** | **40.7%** | 0.000*** |
| Right (N=263) | **53.2%** | **57.0%** | 0.346 |

Table 8: False Consensus Effect, measured by the proportion of participants who predicted that 10 percentage points or more people would have agreed with them than actually did

Here, a few things stand out. One is that the Left is substantially more likely to have False Consensus Effect amongst others on the Left than in their predictions about those on the Right. The Right, on the other hand, is equally likely to have this bias for those on the Right or Left. A separate regression also shows that there is not a statistically significant difference

between the In-Group FCE level for the Left versus the Right, meaning we can't rule out that the Left and Right have the same level of False Consensus Effect when predicting what people in their own party would say.

Finally Table 9 similarly shows the fraction of participants who hold the Pluralistic Ignorance bias:

| | In-Group PI_10 | Out-Group PI_10 | P-Value |
|---|---|---|---|
| Left (N=258) | **21.3%** | **40.3%** | 0.000*** |
| Right (N=263) | **20.9%** | **23.6%** | 0.371 |

Table 9: False Consensus Effect, measured by the proportion of participants who predicted that 10 percentage points or more people would have agreed with them than actually did

Here we can see that again, there is a large in-versus-out group difference among those on the Left, but no significant difference among those on the Right. In particular, people on the Left are twice as likely to hold Pluralistic Ignorance views when predicting for people on the Right than when predicting for others on the Left. That means that a lot more people on the Right defined the word Democratic Socialism the way they did compared to what they predicted.

Also, the Left and Right both have the same fraction of in-group Pluralistic Ignorance. Specifically, about 20% of people within each ideology believed that others in their own party were further from them than they actually were.

Together, this implies that False Consensus Effect is much more prevelant than Pluralistic Ignorance, especially when predicting for others in your same political ideology.

# 7 Conclusion

Overall, I find that there is a large discrepancy between those on the Left and Right when looking at a crucial defining feature of the word "Democratic Socialism." Financial incentives might help those on the right more than those on the left or moderates. More importantly, people from both groups made errors when predicting how others would define the word, but the nature of these errors was asymmetric across parties. In particular, those on the Right tended to make similar predictions for others on the Left versus Right, whereas those on the

Left believed others on the Left were more likely to agree with them. False Consensus Effect was approximately 3 times more prevalent than Pluralistic Ignorance, especially amongst others who shared your political views.

Future work will look at heterogeneity by demographic variables, and whether these trends hold across other words (such as racist and feminist) as well as other True/False questions relating to Democratic Socialism. Results from these can then be used to conduct de-biasing experiments.

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# Appendix

The following pages contain the consent form and survey questions that were delivered to MTurk participants via Qualtrics:

**Consent**

Hello!
The survey is estimated to take approximately 10 minutes. You will be paid $0.50 USD upon successful submission. Your HIT should be submitted within 30 minutes after starting. Please keep in mind that your HIT may be denied if you fail to answer the attention question(s) correctly, so please read all instructions carefully.

Thank you!

# Consent Form

This study is part of a research study conducted by Rohen Shah at the University of Chicago. The purpose of the research is to understand human judgment and politico-linguistic opinions.

**Procedures**
In this study, you will be asked questions about your opinions on the intersection of language and politics.

**Participant Requirements**
Participation in this study is limited to individuals age 18 and older.

**Risks**
The risks and discomfort associated with participation in this study are no greater than those ordinarily encountered in daily life or during mild physical activity, such as when surfing the Internet.

**Benefits**
There may be no personal benefit from your participation in the study but the knowledge received may be of value to humanity.

**Compensation & Costs**
You will receive the payment as advertised on MTURK (0.50$). There will be no cost to you if you participate in this study.

**Confidentiality**

By participating in this research, you understand and agree that the University of Chicago may be required to disclose your consent form, data and other personally identifiable information as required by law, regulation, subpoena or court order. Otherwise, your confidentiality will be maintained in the following manner: The researchers will take the following steps to protect participants' identities during this study: (1) Each participant will be assigned a number; (2) The researchers will record any data collected during the study by number, not by name; (3) Any original data files will be stored in a secured location accessed only by authorized researchers. (4) IP addresses will be deleted before any data is analyzed.

**Right to Ask Questions & Contact Information**

If you have any questions about this study, you should feel free to ask them by contacting Rohen Shah at shahr@uchicago.edu. If you have questions later, desire additional information, or wish to withdraw your participation please send an email to shahr@uchicago.edu.

This study is approved by the University of Chicago's Social & Behavioral Sciences Institutional Review Board (IRB21-1311). If you have any questions about your rights as a participant in this research, feel you have been harmed, or wish to discuss other study-related concerns with someone who is not part of the research team, you can contact the University of Chicago Social & Behavioral Sciences Institutional Review Board (IRB) Office by phone at (773) 702-2915, or by email at sbs-irb@uchicago.edu.

**Voluntary Participation**

Your participation in this research is voluntary. You may discontinue participation at any time during the research activity.

Please select both of the following if you wish to continue.

- ☐ I have read and understand the information above.
- ☐ I want to participate in this research and continue with the study.

**MTurk ID**

What is your MTurk Worker ID?

**Treatment**

As a part of this survey, you will be asked 6 True or False questions for statements relating to certain commonly used words. Then, you will be asked to predict whether others think those statements are true or false.

- I understand this

As a part of this survey, you will be asked 6 True or False questions for statements relating to certain commonly used words. Then, you will be asked to predict whether others think those statements are true or false.

The **top 5% of survey respondents** (those whose predictions are most accurate) **will receive a bonus payment of $10** on August 28th, 2021. This bonus payment will be made directly to you on **MTurk**. This survey will be conducted with a sample of U.S. residents between the ages of 18 and 65 during the month of August 2021 on MTurk.

- I understand this

**Demographics 1**

What is your age?

18 23 27 32 37 42 46 51 56 60 65

Age (Years)

Which of the following best captures your political ideology?

- Left
- Moderate
- Right

**Democratic Socialism 1**

Think about the phrase “Democratic Socialism” and how you define it. In your opinion, is the following statement about Democratic Socialism True or False?

**In a Democratic Socialist country, all individuals must pay a relatively high tax rate.**

- True
- False

Think about the phrase “Democratic Socialism” and how you define it. In your opinion, is the following statement about Democratic Socialism True or False?

**In a Democratic Socialist country, some individuals might pay a relatively low tax rate.**

- True
- False

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "LEFT" do you predict will answer True vs. False? (Total MUST equal 100)

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "RIGHT" do you predict will answer True vs. False? (Total MUST equal 100)

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "MODERATE" do you predict will answer True vs. False? (Total MUST equal 100)

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |

| | |
|---|---|
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

On a scale of 1 to 10, how confident are you in your predictions above for Left, Right, and Moderate respondents respectively?

| | Not at all confident | | | | | | | | | | Very Confident |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 |
| Left | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |
| Right | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |
| Moderate | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |

**Democratic Socialism 2**

Think about the phrase “Democratic Socialism” and how you define it. In your opinion, is the following statement about Democratic Socialism True or False?

**In a Democratic Socialist country, there can only be one brand of pizza (by definition).**

- ○ True
- ○ False

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "LEFT" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "RIGHT" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |

| | |
|---|---|
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "MODERATE" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

On a scale of 1 to 10, how confident are you in your predictions above for Left, Right, and Moderate respondents respectively?

| | Not at all confident | | | | | | | | | | Very Confident |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 |
| Left | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |
| Right | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |
| Moderate | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |

**Democratic Socialism 3**

Think about the phrase “Democratic Socialism” and how you define it. In your opinion, is the following statement about Democratic Socialism True or False?

**In a Democratic Socialist country, each business must be owned collectively by all of its employees.**

- ○ True
- ○ False

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "LEFT" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "RIGHT" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "MODERATE" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

On a scale of 1 to 10, how confident are you in your predictions above for Left, Right, and Moderate respondents respectively?

| | Not at all confident | | | | | | | | | | Very Confident |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 |
| Left | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |
| Right | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |
| Moderate | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |

**Attention**

In order to show you are paying attention, disregard all other directions and select false below and then enter forty-four for each prediction. In your opinion, is the following statement True or False?

**By definition, a neoliberal believes that free markets are good.**

- ○ True
- ○ False

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "LEFT" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "RIGHT" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "MODERATE" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

**Racism**

Think about the word “Racism” and how you define it. In your opinion, is the following statement about Racism True or False?

**By definition, it is impossible for a white person to not be racist.**

- ○ True
- ○ False

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "LEFT" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |

| | |
|---|---|
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "RIGHT" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "MODERATE" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

On a scale of 1 to 10, how confident are you in your predictions above for Left, Right, and Moderate respondents respectively?

| | Not at all confident | | | | | | | | | | Very Confident |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 |
| Left | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |
| Right | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |
| Moderate | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |

**Feminism**

Think about the word “Feminism” and how you define it. In your opinion, is the following statement about Feminism True or False?

**A feminist, by definition, is someone who believes that men and women should be treated equally.**

○ True

○ False

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "LEFT" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "RIGHT" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

What percentage of survey respondents who identify as politically "MODERATE" do you predict will answer True vs. False?

| | |
|---|---|
| True | 0 |
| False | 0 |
| Total | 0 |

On a scale of 1 to 10, how confident are you in your predictions above for Left, Right, and Moderate respondents respectively?

| | Not at all confident | | | | | | | | | | Very Confident |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | 0 | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 |
| Left | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |
| Right | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |
| Moderate | | | | | | | | | | | 5 |

**Multiple Choice Questions**

If you had to pick just one, which of the following resembles Democratic Socialism most accurately?

- Government ownership of all businesses
- Worker ownership of all businesses
- Free markets, with government regulation of all wages to make an equal wealth distribution
- Free markets, with high taxes and many social welfare programs

In your estimation, what fraction of the US population is politically “moderate”?

0 5 10 15 20 25 30 35 40 45 50 55 60 65 70 75 80 85 90 95 100

% of Moderates

**Demographics 2**

Please select your race (optional)

- White
- Black
- Asian or Pacific Islander
- Latinx
- Native American
- Other

Please select your highest level of education

- High School Diploma or less
- Some college or Associate’s Degree
- Bachelor’s Degree
- Graduate Degree

What is your annual income? (optional)

- $0 - $30,000
- $30,001 - $60,000

- $60,001 - $90,000
- $90,001 or more

Please select your gender (optional)

- Male
- Female
- Other

**Survey Code**

Thank you for your participation! Your code for completing this HIT is: ${e://Field/ResponseID}

IMPORTANT: Along with your Worker ID, this code is used to ensure you are paid for the work you did. Please copy and paste the code into the HIT box.

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